



BERLIN GERMANY

Prussian Pork in Berlin

Berlin's outward-looking dynamism, nonconformism, and hip self-confidence have transformed it into one of Europe's most exciting cities. Many world cuisines flourish here, but in the city's corner pubs, earthy traditional favorites such as *Eisbein* still survive. This tender pork knuckle dish allows a rare taste of the flavors of Berlin in its heyday, as the capital of Prussia.



Berlin had a famously eventful 20th century, to say the least. The Nazi era and the city's subsequent near-obliteration in

World War II, followed by its division by opposing ideologies and the Berlin Wall, all left the city deeply scarred. With points of interest that are often somber and include bombed-out churches, remains of the Wall, and dozens of memorials to almost unimaginable horrors, it's not really a place for light-hearted sightseeing, yet exploring its layers of history quickly becomes a compelling activity.

But it's not all gravitas in Berlin. Reunification and an almost constant rebuilding process have fostered a creative atmosphere that encourages the lively and offbeat, evident in the city's many festivals, its thriving arts scene, and its intense nightlife. The rebuilding has left the city with a showcase of cutting-edge architecture and its museums have a wealth of treasures to rival any national collection.

Berlin is also inventive in its food and restaurants, which include places where food is served in the dark by blind waiters, or where you pay according to how

wealthy you feel. Yet its traditional foods speak of a simpler and earthier time, ruled by calorific dishes like *Eisbein*, which was a particular favorite of both philosopher Immanuel Kant and singer and actress Marlene Dietrich. The enduring popularity of the dish has something to do with Germany's love of pork – the country eats more of it than all other meats and poultry combined. This love affair dates back to Roman times, when wild boar was the meat of choice at feasts. Fresh, pickled, or smoked pork became the basis for hundreds of specialties, and there's a recipe in traditional German cuisine for every part of the animal.

Eisbein is a heavily fat-marbled cut of cured pork clinging to a large bone; it frequently unsettles unwary and squeamish visitors, but remains a firm favorite among Berliners. The pork is cured and sometimes smoked before it is soaked overnight in brine or rubbed with salt, pepper, garlic, and caraway seeds. Its extreme tenderness comes from hours of slow simmering, after which it is served with simple vegetables, such as sauerkraut, puréed peas, and boiled potatoes. First mentioned in a Berlin cookbook in 1638, *Eisbein* is a genuine taste of the past.



Above Berlin embraces the old and the new, from its magnificent cathedral to its high-tech telecom tower

Cooking Courses

Berliners have developed a healthy interest in world food, and most courses at cooking schools reflect this. But you can also find instruction on mastering the basics of German cuisine together with cooking modern and traditional German recipes. **Kochetage** (www.kochetage.de) is a highly rated Berlin school whose range of courses include instruction on preparing meat, game dishes, and German sauces. **Kochschule Berlin** (www.kochschule-berlin.de) offers a huge number of courses, including those on the basics of German cooking and its traditional dishes. **Kochatelier Berlin** (www.kochatelier-berlin.de) offers a broad range of courses, including "Oma's Küche" (grandmother's kitchen) and the "Berlin-Brandenburg," lessons on traditional cooking using local ingredients.

A Day in Berlin

Central Berlin gathers around the city's pivotal grand avenue, Unter den Linden, and is compact enough to be explored on foot.

MORNING Begin at the west end of **Unter den Linden**, at the **Brandenburg Gate**. Then ascend the impressive cupola of the neighboring **Reichstag**, Germany's parliament, for city views. Afterward visit the giant **Holocaust Memorial** on the other side of the Brandenburg Gate and wander through **Tiergarten Park** to the impressive modern architecture of **Potsdamer Platz**.

AFTERNOON Follow the former course of the **Berlin Wall**, passing a preserved section en route to **Checkpoint Charlie**, the famous former Iron Curtain checkpoint. Then walk north through the **Gendarmenmarkt**, Berlin's most elegant plaza, to **Bebelplatz**, a square surrounded by stately Neo-Classical buildings, before exploring the adjacent **Museum Island**, the location of Berlin's greatest museums.

EVENING Pass through the **Nikolaiviertel**, a rebuilt version of old Berlin, on the way to the distinctive **Fernsehturm Television Tower** for night views of city. Afterward, explore **Hackescher Markt** nightlife area to the northwest.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Berlin's **Schoenefeld Airport** is being expanded to become Berlin Brandenburg International (BBI) in 2012. The city has an excellent network of **metro trains, buses, and trams**.

WHERE TO STAY

Circus Hotel (inexpensive) is a youthful and central hotel with classy, colorful rooms and a beer garden. www.circus-berlin.de

Luise Kunsthôtel (moderate) is an eccentric and attractive art hotel in an 1820s building near the Brandenburg Gate. www.luise-berlin.com

Adlon (expensive) is the *grande dame* of Berlin's hotels, with an elegant 1920s feel and first-class service and amenities. www.hotel-adlon.de

TOURIST INFORMATION
www.tourist.visitberlin.de